

Pakistan



Area 310,403 sq miles
(803,940 sq km)
Population 177 million
Capital Islamabad
Currency Pakistani rupee
Official language Urdu
Life expectancy 65 years



Formerly a part of British India, the Islamic Republic of Pakistan was created in 1947. Initially, it included East Pakistan, present-day Bangladesh, which split from Pakistan in 1971. Punjabis account for more than 50 percent of the population, while Sindhis, Pathans (Pashtuns), and Baluchi make up most of the rest.

Nepal



▲ **PRAYER FLAGS**
Hanging prayer flags high up in the Himalayan mountains is an old Buddhist tradition to promote peace and compassion.

Bangladesh



Area 55,598 sq miles
(144,000 sq km)
Population 150 million
Capital Dhaka
Currency Taka
Official languages Bengali
Life expectancy 64 years



Located around the fertile plains of the Ganges and Jamuna rivers, Bangladesh is one of the world's most densely populated countries. It was a part of Pakistan until 1971. Bangladesh's major economic sectors are jute, textiles, and agriculture.

India



Area 1,269,345 sq miles
(3,287,590 sq km)
Population 1.24 billion
Capital New Delhi
Currency Indian rupee
Official languages Hindi and English
Life expectancy 64 years



India is the world's largest democracy and the second most populous country after China. It is one of the fastest-growing economies in the world. However, wealth distribution is uneven and a huge gap exists between the affluent urban classes and the rural poor. The majority are Hindus, with a minority of Muslims, Christians, and Sikhs.



▲ **THE TAJ MAHAL**
A white marble mausoleum in Agra, the Taj Mahal is a World Heritage Site and one of India's most famous tourist attractions.

Bhutan



Area 18,147 sq miles
(47,000 sq km)
Population 700,000
Capital Thimphu
Currency Ngultrum
Official language Dzongkha
Life expectancy 65 years



The Kingdom of Bhutan is formally a Buddhist state where power is shared by the king and the government. Perched in the Himalayas between India and China, it is 70 percent forested. Strict control over logging—thanks to traditional Buddhist values of respecting nature—has ensured that many of its forests remain untouched.

Maldives



Area 116 sq miles
(300 sq km)
Population 300,000
Capital Malé
Currency Rufiyaa
Official language Dhivehi
Life expectancy 68 years



The Maldives is an archipelago of 1,191 small coral islands in the Indian Ocean. Only 200 of these islands are inhabited. A popular tourist destination, the Maldives is known for its sandy beaches and abundant sea life.



▲ **SAREE**
The saree—a long cloth draped over the body in various styles—is a traditional garment of the women living in the Indian subcontinent.